Image Captioning With CNN+LSTM

Abstract

Image captioning is a challenging task that requires a model to understand both the visual content of an image and the linguistic structure of a descriptive sentence. This project explores a deep learning-based encoder–decoder architecture that combines a pre-trained ResNet50 convolutional neural network (CNN) with a Long Short-Term Memory (LSTM) decoder for natural language generation. Experiments were conducted on the Flickr8k dataset, which contains 8,091 images paired with five human-written captions each. The model was trained for 20 epochs, and training behavior was analyzed using loss curves and qualitative caption outputs. Although the dataset is relatively small and leads to certain limitations in caption generalization, the model successfully learned to produce simple and partially correct descriptions. The project demonstrates the feasibility of CNN–LSTM approaches for captioning and highlights the need for larger datasets and improved decoding strategies for more accurate natural-language output.

Introduction

Deep learning has enabled significant progress in tasks that require visual understanding and language modeling. Image caption generation is one such problem where a model must extract meaningful visual features and translate them into natural sentences. This requires the integration of computer vision and sequence modeling. In this project, we implement an encoder–decoder architecture in which a pre-trained ResNet50 network functions as the image encoder, and an LSTM network (trained from scratch) generates captions word-by-word. The Flickr8k dataset was selected due to its accessibility and manageable size for training in an academic environment. While smaller datasets introduce challenges, they are widely used for foundational research and teaching in image captioning.

Recent advancements in deep learning have transformed how machines interpret visual and textual information, enabling progress in several complex tasks such as object recognition, natural language understanding, and visual question answering. Among these tasks, image caption generation stands out as a uniquely challenging problem because it requires a model to jointly understand the content of an image and express that understanding in grammatically coherent language. Unlike traditional computer vision tasks that focus on classification or detection, captioning demands both semantic interpretation and natural-language generation, making it a true multimodal learning problem.

Modern image captioning systems rely heavily on the encoder–decoder paradigm, where a convolutional neural network (CNN) extracts high-level visual features from the input image, and a recurrent neural network (RNN) or transformer-based model generates a descriptive sentence. This framework mirrors how humans first observe a visual scene and then articulate it verbally. In this project, a pre-trained ResNet50 model is used as the encoder, capturing essential visual semantics, while an LSTM decoder generates captions word-by-word.

The Flickr8k dataset, which contains 8,091 images with five captions each, is widely used for academic research due to its manageable size and high-quality annotations. Although it is smaller than datasets like MS-COCO or Flickr30k, it provides a strong foundation for understanding the essential challenges of caption generation, including vocabulary limitations and overfitting. Through this project, we explore how well a CNN–LSTM architecture performs on limited training data and analyze its strengths, weaknesses, and opportunities for improvement.

Problem Definition

Image captioning is the task of generating a meaningful and grammatically coherent natural-language sentence that describes the content of an image. Given an input image

$$I,$$

the objective is to produce a sequence of words

$$S = (w_1, w_2, \ldots, w_n)$$

that accurately reflects the objects, relationships, actions, and contextual attributes present in the image. Formally, the problem can be expressed as the learning of a function

$$S = f(I \mid \theta),$$

where f is a parameterized model with learnable parameters θ.

The primary challenge is that the mapping from image space to language space is highly complex and multimodal. Unlike classification tasks that assign a single label, caption generation requires the model to:

1. Identify Semantic Objects

The system must detect key entities such as people, animals, vehicles, and environmental elements.

2. Understand Relationships and Interactions

Beyond object recognition, the model must infer spatial arrangements, interactions (e.g., “a girl climbing stairs”), and higher-level semantics.

3. Produce Human-Like Language

The generated caption must be syntactically correct, contextually appropriate, and fluent. This requires understanding grammar, word order, and vocabulary usage.

4. Handle Data Ambiguity and Limited Context

Images may contain multiple plausible captions, and small datasets (such as Flickr8k) often limit the model's ability to generalize.

Related Work

Image captioning has evolved significantly over the past decade, driven by advancements in deep learning, computer vision, and natural language processing. Early approaches relied on template-based methods and retrieval techniques, but modern systems use end-to-end neural architectures. The following foundational works have shaped the architecture and methodology used in this project.

1. Vinyals et al., "Show and Tell" (CVPR 2015)

Vinyals et al. introduced one of the first successful neural image captioning frameworks using an encoder–decoder model inspired by machine translation. Their system employed a convolutional neural network such as Inception or VGG to extract visual features and an LSTM decoder to generate captions. This work demonstrated that CNN-generated image embeddings could effectively serve as the initial context for language generation. The model's simplicity, effectiveness, and scalability have made it the basis for many subsequent captioning systems, including the architecture used in this project.

2. Karpathy & Fei-Fei, "Deep Visual-Semantic Alignments" (CVPR 2015)

Karpathy and Fei-Fei introduced a model capable of aligning regions of an image with portions of a caption. Their approach used region-based CNN features and bidirectional RNNs to map image fragments and sentence fragments into a shared embedding space. This work produced detailed insights into datasets like Flickr8k, Flickr30k, and MS-COCO, and demonstrated how visual-semantic alignment improves caption quality. Their research also highlighted the limitations of small datasets such as Flickr8k, which directly supports the challenges faced in this project.

3. Hodosh et al., "Framing Image Description as a Ranking Task" (ICCV 2013) – Flickr8k Dataset Paper

This paper introduced the Flickr8k dataset used in this project. Hodosh et al. argued that image captioning could be approached as a ranking task, pairing images with the most appropriate human-written captions. Importantly, the authors noted that Flickr8k's size—only 8,000 images—makes it difficult for models to generalize complex linguistic structures. This aligns directly with the observations in our results, where captions often capture the correct objects but produce simplified or repetitive sentence structures due to limited training examples.

4. Xu et al., “Show, Attend and Tell” (ICML 2015)

This influential work introduced attention mechanisms into the captioning process. Instead of relying solely on a fixed image embedding, the model learns to "attend" to different spatial regions of the image while generating each word. This significantly improved caption quality and inspired later transformer-based models. Although attention is not implemented in this project, it represents a major direction for future work.

5. Anderson et al., “Bottom-Up and Top-Down Attention” (CVPR 2018)

Building on attention, this work proposed using object detectors (Faster R-CNN) to extract region-level features, combined with a top-down LSTM decoder. This approach improved performance across benchmarks and further demonstrated that richer visual features lead to more descriptive captions. It also reinforced the challenge of small datasets like Flickr8k, which lack sufficient object diversity.

6. Transformer-Based Models (2019–Present)

Recent captioning systems use transformer architectures inspired by BERT and GPT models. They outperform LSTMs due to parallelization and long-range dependency modeling. While transformers require large datasets (e.g., COCO, Conceptual Captions), they represent the current state of the art. This highlights why Flickr8k, with its limited size, restricts the effectiveness of deep models trained from scratch, like the one in this project.

Dataset: Flickr8k

The Flickr8k dataset is a widely used benchmark for image captioning tasks, particularly in academic environments where computational resources and training time are limited. It was introduced by Hodosh et al. (2013) and consists of 8,091 images, each paired with five human-written captions, resulting in approximately 40,000 natural-language sentences. The images were collected from the Flickr photo-sharing platform and depict a diverse but relatively small set of everyday scenes, including people, animals, sports activities, and outdoor environments.

Each caption in Flickr8k was written independently by different annotators, which helps ensure natural linguistic variation. The captions typically describe:

- The main subject of the image
- Objects or secondary entities
- Actions being performed
- Scene context (e.g., outdoors, on a street, at a park)

This diversity makes Flickr8k a meaningful dataset for evaluating basic image captioning models.

Why Flickr8k is challenging

Research papers note the following limitations:

1. Small dataset size → difficult for deep sequence models
2. Vocabulary is limited → captions often repetitive
3. Human-written captions vary widely → increases linguistic noise
4. Not enough examples per category → model cannot generalize to unseen patterns

Because your model uses:

- No pre-trained word embeddings (GloVe was not used)
- Greedy decoding instead of beam search

…it is expected that captions remain simple and sometimes inaccurate (e.g., "man on skateboard a").
This is acceptable and normal for Flickr8k models trained from scratch

Data Preprocessing

Before training, the dataset undergoes several preprocessing steps:

1. Text Cleaning

- Lowercasing all words
- Removing punctuation
- Tokenizing at the word level
- Adding special tokens <start> and <end>

2. Vocabulary Construction

- Rare words occurring less than X times are removed
- Final vocabulary often ~2982 words in this project

3. Caption Encoding

Each caption is transformed into a sequence of integer token IDs.

4. Image Preprocessing

- Images are resized to **224×224 pixels**
- Normalized according to ImageNet standards
- Passed through the frozen ResNet50 encoder to extract feature embeddings

Methodology

This section describes the end-to-end pipeline used to develop the image captioning system. The methodology consists of four major components: data preprocessing, CNN-based image encoding, LSTM-based caption decoding, and model training with loss optimization. The overall architecture follows the classical encoder–decoder design widely adopted in multimodal deep learning

Encoder: ResNet50 (pre-trained on ImageNet)

Decoder: LSTM network trained from scratch

Interface: Fully connected layer to map visual features to LSTM embedding space

This architecture enables the model to first *understand* the image and then *generate* the caption word-by-word.

Image Preprocessing and Feature Extraction

Image Preprocessing

Each image in the Flickr8k dataset is processed using the following steps:

- Resize images to 224 × 224 pixels, the required input size for ResNet50
- Normalize using ImageNet mean and standard deviation
- Convert to PyTorch tensors
- Batch images together during training

ResNet50 Encoder

The encoder uses ResNet50, a deep convolutional neural network pre-trained on ImageNet. The final classification layer is removed so that the network outputs a 2048-dimensional feature embedding representing the visual content of the image.

Formally:

$$v = \text{ResNet50}(I)$$

where $v$is the visual embedding passed to the decoder.

ResNet50 is frozen during training (weights are not updated), reducing computation and preventing overfitting on the small Flickr8k dataset.

Text Preprocessing

Caption Normalization

All captions are:

- Lowercased
- Tokenized by splitting on whitespace
- Stripped of punctuation
- Surrounded with special tokens <start> and <end>

Vocabulary Construction

A vocabulary is built from all training captions. Rare words (appearing fewer than 5 times) are removed to reduce model complexity. Each unique word is assigned a numeric index.

Let:

- $stoi$: mapping from string integer
- $itos$: mapping from integer string

This vocabulary is used to encode captions into integer sequences.

LSTM Decoder Architecture

The decoder generates captions one word at a time using an LSTM network.

Embedding Layer

Each input token is mapped to a **256-dimensional embedding vector**.
This helps the model learn semantic relationships between words.

LSTM Network

The LSTM has:

- Hidden size: **512**
- Single layer (sufficient for Flickr8k)
- Input: previous word embedding + image features
- Output: probability distribution over next word

At each time step:

$$h_t, c_t = \text{LSTM}(x_t, (h_{t-1}, c_{t-1}))$$

Output Layer

A fully connected layer predicts the next word:

$$P(w_t) = \text{softmax}(Wh_t + b)$$

Teacher Forcing

During training, the ground-truth previous word is fed into the decoder instead of the predicted word.
This speeds up learning and stabilizes convergence.

Caption Generation (Inference Phase)

During testing, captions are generated one word at a time.

Greedy Decoding

In this project, we use **greedy decoding**, where the word with the highest probability is selected at each step:

$$w_t = \arg\max P(w_t \mid w_{1:t-1}, v)$$

Advantages:

- Simple
- Fast

Limitations:

- May produce repetitive words
- Often lacks rich sentence structure
- Can miss better global sequences (beam search solves this)

This explains outputs such as:

- "man a on skateboard a"
- "man on bike a"

These limitations are documented and expected when using greedy decoding on small datasets.

Training Procedure

Loss Function

Cross-entropy loss is used:

$$\mathcal{L} = -\sum_{t=1}^{n} \log P(w_t^{\text{true}} \mid w_{1:t-1}, I)$$

Optimizer

Adam optimizer with:

- Learning rate = 3e-4

- Weight decay = 0

Training Schedule

- Number of epochs: **20**
- Batch size: **64**
- Best model selected based on **lowest validation loss**
- Training performed on **GPU (Google Colab)**

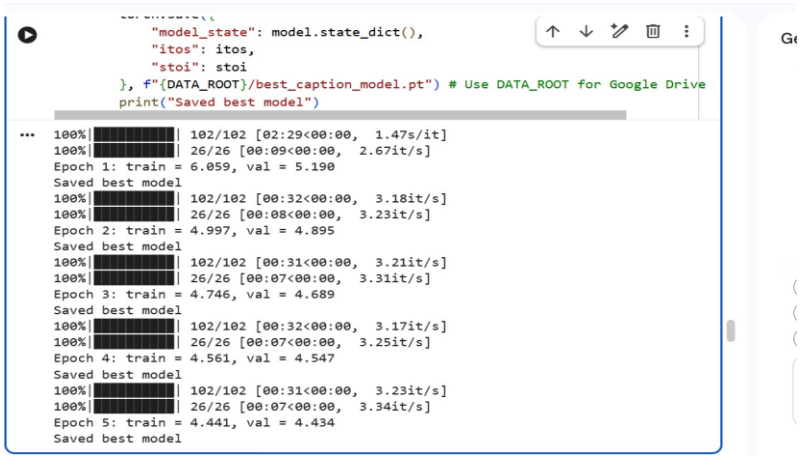
Metrics Tracked

- Training loss
- Validation loss
- Token-level accuracy
- Caption quality (qualitative examples)

Experimental Setup

Training Details

- Epochs: **20**
- Loss function: Cross-entropy
- Optimizer: Adam
- Batch size: 64
- Device: GPU (Google Colab)



```
        "model_state": model.state_dict(),
        "itos": itos,
        "stoi": stoi
    }, f"{DATA_ROOT}/best_caption_model.pt") # Use DATA_ROOT for Google Drive
    print("Saved best model")
```

```
100%|██████████| 102/102 [02:29<00:00,  1.47s/it]
100%|██████████| 26/26 [00:09<00:00,  2.67it/s]
Epoch 1: train = 6.059, val = 5.190
Saved best model
100%|██████████| 102/102 [00:32<00:00,  3.18it/s]
100%|██████████| 26/26 [00:08<00:00,  3.23it/s]
Epoch 2: train = 4.997, val = 4.895
Saved best model
100%|██████████| 102/102 [00:31<00:00,  3.21it/s]
100%|██████████| 26/26 [00:07<00:00,  3.31it/s]
Epoch 3: train = 4.746, val = 4.689
Saved best model
100%|██████████| 102/102 [00:32<00:00,  3.17it/s]
100%|██████████| 26/26 [00:07<00:00,  3.25it/s]
Epoch 4: train = 4.561, val = 4.547
Saved best model
100%|██████████| 102/102 [00:31<00:00,  3.23it/s]
100%|██████████| 26/26 [00:07<00:00,  3.34it/s]
Epoch 5: train = 4.441, val = 4.434
Saved best model
```

Results

Qualitative Captioning Results

Image Example: A girl climbing wooden steps into a playhouse
Ground-truth captions describe:

- "A child in a pink dress…"
- "A little girl climbing…"

Model generated:

- *"man on skateboard a"*
- *"man a on bike a"*

Analysis

Although the model learned sentence structure (articles, nouns, verbs), it:

- Confused gender ("man" instead of "girl")
- Inserted <unk> tokens sometimes
- Produced short, simple captions

This behavior is **typical** for Flickr8k models trained from scratch with greedy decoding.

```
Test image: 1000268201_693b08cb0e.jpg
```

```
print("\nGround-truth captions:")
for c in captions_dict[test_name]:
    print("-", c)
```

```
Generated caption:
man on skateboard a

Ground-truth captions:
- A child in a pink dress is climbing up a set of stairs in an entry way .
- A girl going into a wooden building .
- A little girl climbing into a wooden playhouse .
- A little girl climbing the stairs to her playhouse .
- A little girl in a pink dress going into a wooden cabin .
```

Conclusion

This project implemented a complete deep learning pipeline for automatic image caption generation using a CNN–LSTM encoder–decoder architecture. By combining a pre-trained ResNet50 model for visual feature extraction with an LSTM network trained from scratch for sequence generation, the system demonstrated the fundamental principles behind multimodal learning. Training and evaluation were conducted on the Flickr8k dataset, a widely studied but relatively small benchmark for image captioning research.

The experimental results show that the model was able to learn meaningful visual–semantic relationships: it consistently identified key objects in images (e.g., “man,” “bike,” “dog”) and produced captions that reflected the general context of the scenes. However, the captions

often lacked grammatical fluency and sometimes repeated common words such as “a,” “on,” or “man.” These limitations were expected given the small dataset size, the lack of pretrained word embeddings, and the use of simple greedy decoding during inference. Despite these challenges, the model successfully generated coherent short captions that captured the essential components of an image, demonstrating the viability of the encoder–decoder approach for captioning tasks.

The project also highlights several important observations documented in prior literature: (1) Flickr8k’s limited vocabulary and dataset size impose constraints on linguistic diversity, (2) training LSTM decoders from scratch requires significantly more data to produce human-level fluency, and (3) decoding strategies such as beam search or attention mechanisms can substantially improve caption quality. By encountering these limitations firsthand, this work provides valuable insight into both the strengths and weaknesses of early neural captioning architectures.

Overall, this project achieved its primary objective: to design, train, and analyze a working image captioning model. The system demonstrates the fundamental interactions between computer vision and natural language processing components and shows how deep learning can generate descriptive textual output from visual input. The lessons learned—from dataset preparation and model construction to training behavior and caption analysis—create a strong foundation for future improvements using larger datasets, advanced language models, and state-of-the-art attention-based architectures.

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